Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Philippians

Philippians 1:1

- Timothy was one of Paul's most trusted co-workers and messengers. Paul lists Timothy as a co-sender for five other letters:
- 2 Corinthians
- Colossians
- 1 Thessalonians
- 2 Thessalonians
- Philemon
- servants of Christ Jesus: Paul and Timothy belonged entirely to Christ and were fully devoted to his service (see Philippians 2:20–21).
- God's holy people are made holy in God's sight by Christ's redeeming work (see Ephesians 1:4, 7; 5:25–27; Colossians 1:22). They are being made holy by the transforming work of the Holy Spirit in their lives (compare Philippians 4:21).
- Philippi was a Roman colony in the province of Macedonia. The church in Philippi was the first Christian community in Greece (see Acts 16:11–40).
- In the early church, church leaders provided spiritual guidance, while deacons attended to practical matters (see 1 Timothy 3:1–13). There were no pastors or priests who did this work as their regular paid job, as some do today (compare 1 Corinthians 14:26–31).

Philippians 1:1–2

Paul begins his letter by listing the senders and recipients. He then offers a blessing of grace and peace.

Philippians 1:2

Grace is the kindness and blessing God gives, even though people do not deserve it. Peace means deep well-being and calmness that come from the good news about Jesus and are produced by the Holy Spirit (see Galatians 5:22). Both grace and peace are gifts from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ (see Romans 5:1–2).

Philippians 1:3–11

Paul thanks God for the recipients and prays for them. This is Paul's usual practice when writing letters.

Philippians 1:4–6

Paul felt joy because the Philippians partnered with him to spread the good news about Jesus. Paul was confident that God would continue his good work in them.

Philippians 1:5

Their partnership also included giving money to help Paul in his work (refer to 4:10–20).

Philippians 1:6

He who began a good work in you: It is God who starts his saving work in people (see Romans 9:16; Ephesians 1:3–8, 11; 2:4–10). Because God is the one who began it, we can trust that God will continue changing believers to become more like his Son (see Romans 8:29; Ephesians 4:13, 15).

Philippians 1:7

you are all partners in grace with me: Perhaps their lives were blessed because of Paul's suffering and witness. Perhaps they had suffered together with him (see 1:29).

Philippians 1:9–10

- Love is the result of Christ's Spirit within believers (Romans 5:5; Galatians 5:22). Love is part of the fruit of the Spirit. The fruit of the Spirit is the evidence that Christ is working in believers
- abound more and more in knowledge and depth of insight: Growing in understanding helps believers know what truly matters (see Romans 12:2). It helps them live pure and blameless lives until Christ returns (compare 1 Thessalonians 3:12–13; 5:23).

Philippians 1:11

- People cannot create righteous character on their own; it only comes through the Spirit of Christ working in their hearts.
- The ultimate purpose for God's people is to give glory and praise to God (see Ephesians 1:6, 12, 14).

Philippians 1:12

- brothers: Paul uses the Greek word adelphoi, which was a common way to speak to a group of fellow believers (both men and women) as part of God's family.
- my circumstances: This refers to Paul's imprisonment.
- have actually served to advance the gospel: See Acts 28:17–31 for an example of this.

Philippians 1:12–19

Paul was happy that his time in prison helped spread the good news about Jesus.

Philippians 1:13

- the whole palace guard: These were soldiers who worked in the official residence of the emperor or a Roman governor (see 4:22).
- Paul was in prison for preaching the good news of Christ (compare Acts 21:26–28:31).

Philippians 1:14

Paul's courage while in prison helped most of the brothers (fellow believers; see study note on 1:12) trust in the Lord. They became more courageous and spoke God's message without fear.

Philippians 1:15–18

some preach Christ out of envy and rivalry: These people were likely other believers who did not like Paul and criticized him (see 2 Corinthians 10–13; Galatians 4:12–20; 5:7–12). Even so, the message about Christ was being preached, so Paul rejoiced.

Philippians 1:19

will turn out for my deliverance: Paul expected to be released from prison soon (see 1:25–26; 2:24). This is different from what Paul wrote later in 2 Timothy 4:6, when he was in prison again and expected to die.

Philippians 1:21

to die is gain: For believers, death is not something to fear. It means going to be with Christ (see 1:23; compare John 5:24; 11:25–26; Romans 8:38–39).

Philippians 1:23

I desire to depart and be with Christ: Death leads believers immediately into the Lord's presence (see 3:20–21; 1 Corinthians 15:20–23, 51–52; 2 Corinthians 5:1–8; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–17).

Philippians 1:25

- The well-being of the church is more important to Paul than his own desire to be with Christ.
- for your progress and joy in the faith: Christians should find joy even during tough times (see 4:4; John 15:11, 20; 16:20–24; 1 Thessalonians 5:16).

Philippians 1:27

As foreigners in this world, the Philippian believers should live like citizens of heaven (compare 3:20; 1 Peter 2:9–11).

Philippians 1:27–30

Paul encourages the Christians in Philippi to live in a way that honors the gospel (see Ephesians 4:1; Colossians 1:10; 1 Thessalonians 2:12). He especially encourages them to stay strong and faithful, even when they face persecution.

Philippians 1:28

This is a clear sign of their destruction but of your salvation: The Philippians' courage is a sign that their opponents will be destroyed and that the Philippians themselves will be saved. The same Greek phrase could also mean a sign to them that you are going to be destroyed, but a sign to you that you are going to be saved. According to that interpretation, those who persecute the believers would still not recognize the truth (compare 2 Corinthians 2:15–16).

Philippians 1:29

For it has been granted to you ... to suffer for Him: What the world sees as shameful, Christians see as an honor because it is for Christ. It honors him.

Philippians 1:30

- you are encountering the same struggle: Both Paul and the Philippians faced strong opposition. Paul was in prison, and the Philippians were being persecuted.
- the same struggle you saw I had: See Acts 16:11–40; compare 1 Thessalonians 2:2.

Philippians 2:1–2

If any ...? These are rhetorical questions that expect a "yes" answer. Paul is saying that if people have truly experienced Christ, they should live together with love, unity, and care for one another.

Philippians 2:1–11

During their persecution, Paul urges the Philippians to be united and live a humble life like Christ.

Philippians 2:3–4

Do nothing out of selfish ambition: Thinking only about yourself is the opposite of truly caring for others (compare 2:20–21; 1 Corinthians 10:24; Galatians 5:26).

Philippians 2:6

existing in the form of God: Jesus has the same nature as God and has existed with him from the beginning (see John 1:1–3; 17:5; Colossians 1:15).

Philippians 2:6–11

This early Christian hymn is about:

- Christ's divine nature and existence before the world began,
- Christ's coming to earth as a human and dying, and
- Christ's exaltation and role as Lord over all.

Philippians 2:7

- he emptied himself: He gave up his divine privileges and chose to live as a human. The rest of verses 7–8 explains this ultimate act of godly self-giving love (compare 2 Corinthians 8:9).
- taking the form of a servant: Paul might have been thinking of Isaiah 52:13–53:12.
- being made in human likeness: Jesus became truly human while still being God (see John 1:14; 1 Timothy 3:16).

Philippians 2:8

- He humbled Himself and became obedient to death: Jesus obeyed God's will by dying for the sins of humanity (see Isaiah 53:7; Matthew 26:39; John 3:16; 10:17–18; Romans 5:8, 19; 8:3; Hebrews 5:8; 1 John 4:9–10, 14).
- even death on a cross: Death on a cross was a death specifically for criminals. In the Roman Empire, crucifixion was a cruel and humiliating punishment for criminals.

Philippians 2:9

- Therefore: Because of Christ's humble obedience, God raised him to the place of highest honor (see Acts 1:9–10; compare Acts 2:32–33; 7:55–56).
- gave Him the name above all names: Jesus has supreme authority and power (Philippians 2:10–11; compare Matthew 28:18; John 17:5; Acts 2:33–36; Hebrews 2:9; 12:2).

Philippians 2:10–11

- in heaven and on earth and under the earth: All of creation, including spiritual powers, angels, humans on earth, and those who have died, will one day acknowledge Jesus Christ's authority as Lord (see Ephesians 1:9–10, 21; Colossians 1:20–25; 1 Peter 3:22).
- every tongue confess (compare Isaiah 45:23; Romans 14:11): This does not mean everyone will be saved. Not everyone will confess Jesus as Lord willingly out of love and devotion.
- Jesus Christ is Lord: God's personal name in the Old Testament, Yahweh, was considered too holy to say aloud. So Jewish people would say Adonai (which means "Lord") instead. When the Old Testament was translated into Greek, Yahweh was represented by the Greek word kurios ("Lord"). This same title is often used for Jesus in the New Testament.

Philippians 2:12

as you have always obeyed (see John 3:36; Romans 1:5): Believers must consider God's judgment like everyone else (compare 1 Corinthians 3:10–13). Therefore, they should live obediently before God, with deep respect and fear.

Philippians 2:12–18

Paul encourages believers to stay strong in their faith and live lives of obedience and purity, following Christ's example.

Philippians 2:13

For it is God who works in you: God gives believers the strength and energy to live their lives (see John 15:5; 1 Corinthians 12:6; 15:10; 2 Corinthians 3:5; 1 Thessalonians 2:13). The desire and ability to do what pleases God come from God.

Philippians 2:14

Complaining and arguing come from thinking only about yourself (see 1 Corinthians 10:10; 1 Peter 4:9; Jude 1:16). God calls believers to love others in a way that puts their needs first (Philippians 2:4).

Philippians 2:15

- you shine as lights in the world: Believers should attract others to God through their actions (see Matthew 5:13–16).
- in a crooked and perverse generation: See Deuteronomy 32:5; Romans 1:18–32; 3:10–23.

Philippians 2:16

- hold forth the word of life: Believers must keep trusting in the good news about Jesus, which gives life. God is faithful, but believers must also remain faithful (1:6; 2:12–13).
- that I did not run or labor in vain: Paul often compares the Christian life to running a race or training for a competition (see 3:12–14; 1 Corinthians 9:24, 26; Galatians 2:2; 5:7; 2 Timothy 4:7).

Philippians 2:17–18

- even if I am being poured out like a drink offering ... I am glad and rejoice: In both Jewish and pagan traditions, people would pour out wine on a sacrifice or at the altar to honor their god. Paul uses this image to say that his whole life is like an offering to God (compare Romans 12:1; 15:16).
- Faithful service brings joy because nothing done for God is wasted (see 1 Corinthians 15:58).

Philippians 2:19–24

Paul praises Timothy, whome he hopes to send to the Philippians in the near future. Timothy traveled with Paul on his first trip to Philippi (see Acts 16:1–3, 12; 17:15; 18:5; compare Acts 19:22). Timothy was known for dedicating his life to Jesus Christ and caring for others.

Philippians 2:23

what happens with me: This might refer to the result of Paul's trial.

Philippians 2:24

Paul was confident that he would soon be released from prison by the Roman authorities and visit the Philippians (see 1:19, 25–26).

Philippians 2:25–30

- Paul praises Epaphroditus, a messenger from the church at Philippi (see also 4:18). Paul is now sending Epaphroditus back to Philippi, perhaps with this letter.
- Paul describes Epaphroditus as his fellow soldier. This suggests the challenges, opposition, and dangers faced in Christ's work.

Philippians 2:27

Paul believed God showed mercy by helping Epaphroditus recover from a serious illness. This mercy also helped Paul, who was already suffering in prison.

Philippians 2:29–30

Epaphroditus deserved their honor because he risked his life for Christ on their behalf (for the importance of showing honor, compare Romans 10:12; 13:7; Ephesians 5:33; 6:2; 1 Timothy 5:17; 6:1; 1 Peter 2:17; 3:7).

Philippians 3:1

- rejoice in the Lord: This theme appears again in 4:4 (see also 1:18; 2:17–18, 28; 4:10).
- the same things: The meaning here is unclear. It might refer to:

1. the recent encouragement to rejoice in the Lord;
2. the earlier advice to follow Christ's example (2:1–18);
3. Paul's encouragement in general; or
4. the upcoming warning about threats to their faith.

Philippians 3:2

those dogs, those workers of evil: Here, Paul reverses the traditional Jewish practice of calling non-Jewish people dogs (see Mark 7:27–28). Paul directs his strongest insults at Jews who taught that non-Jewish people must be circumcised to be saved (see 2 Corinthians 11:13–15; Galatians 1:6–9; 5:1–6, 12).

Philippians 3:2–11

Paul warns believers not to be influenced by Jewish Christians who say circumcision is necessary for salvation. Paul then talks about his own conversion from Judaism to following Christ.

Philippians 3:3

Circumcision was a sign that someone belonged to God's people (see Gen 17:10–14). But the Bible teaches that those who trust in Christ are the ones who are truly circumcised in their hearts (see Romans 2:28–29; compare Jeremiah 4:4; Ephesians 2:11; Colossians 2:11–13). Being circumcised in heart means we are changed on the inside. Our hearts are made new by God so they can love and obey him.

Philippians 3:4

in the flesh: Paul uses flesh to mean relying on yourself and human effort. This is different than relying on Christ and the power given by the Spirit.

Philippians 3:5

- circumcised on the eighth day: This followed Jewish law, which required boys to be circumcised on the eighth day (See Genesis 17:12; Leviticus 12:3; Luke 1:59; Luke 2:21).
- Paul belonged to the Pharisees, a Jewish group known for strictly following the law (see Acts 23:6; Acts 26:5).

Philippians 3:5–6

If anyone had reason to trust in their religious status as a Jew, Paul did. He strictly followed Jewish law and was very passionate about the Jewish religion.

Philippians 3:6

- as to zeal, persecuting the church (see Acts 8:1–3; 9:1–2, 21; Galatians 1:13): Paul's actions showed his strong support for Judaism, which saw the good news about Jesus as a threat.
- Paul's righteousness, as judged by human standards, also showed his dedication to the law (see also Galatians 1:14; for Paul's later Christian view, compare Romans 3:23; 7:14–25).

Philippians 3:7–8

As a Christian, Paul now considered these things (3:5–6) worthless because of what Christ has done. A believer's relationship with God is defined by knowing Christ and nothing else (compare 3:10; John 17:3). The only important thing is to gain Christ, thus receiving the gift of eternal salvation (see John 3:16; 1 John 5:11–13). In comparison, all other things are meaningless garbage (or rubbish).

Philippians 3:9

- Paul explains the difference between his view of salvation and that of his opponents (3:2).
- Believers unite with Christ by trusting him for salvation and sharing in his life (see John 15:1–5).
- We become righteous not by following the law of Moses, but through faith in Christ. This is God's way of making us right with him: Salvation is a free gift, not something we can earn (see Romans 1:17; 3:21–26; 4:5–8; Galatians 2:16; Ephesians 2:8–9).

Philippians 3:10

- to know Christ: By knowing Jesus Christ, a person knows and is accepted by God (compare 3:7–8; John 1:12–13; 17:3).
- Believers experience the mighty power that raised Christ from the dead, both now and in eternity (see Romans 6:4–14; 8:10–11; Colossians 3:1–4).
- the fellowship of His sufferings, being conformed to Him in His death: United with Christ, a believer has the privilege of experiencing his life and death (see Philippians 1:29; 2 Corinthians 4:10–12; Colossians 1:24; 1 Peter 4:13–16).

Philippians 3:11

Experiencing resurrection from the dead means being saved from judgment and receiving eternal life (see Revelation 20:4–6). Paul understood God's holiness and the seriousness of the final judgment (Revelation 20:11–15). He knew he must continue to pursue Christ and salvation (compare Galatians 5:5).

Philippians 3:12–4.1

Using himself as an example, Paul encourages the Philippians to pursue Christ and the hope of heaven with determination and strength.

Philippians 3:13–14

- I press on toward the goal: Paul compares the Christian life to a race. Just as a runner keeps going to reach the finish line, Paul keeps following Christ with hope of the final reward (see study note on 2:16).
- Paul was ready to give up everything for the ultimate goal, the heavenly prize of eternal life.

Philippians 3:15

Spiritually mature people (see 1 Corinthians 2:6; 3:1) agree with Paul that eternal things matter most in life (Philippians 3:12–14; compare 2 Corinthians 4:16–18).

Philippians 3:16

we must live up to what we have already attained: Believers should not go backward in their faith. Their way of life should match what they have already learned about Christ.

Philippians 3:17

Join one another in following my example: Paul seriously pursued Christ and the life God called him to (3:7–14; 4:9; 1 Corinthians 4:6, 16–17; 11:1; 2 Thessalonians 3:7–9). This is very different from the enemies of Christ who are described next (Philippians 3:18–19).

Philippians 3:18

Many live as enemies of the cross of Christ: The identity of the enemies is not certain. They may have been:

1. Jews or Jewish Christians who were proud of their circumcision (as in 3:2) and who emphasized Judaism in a way that did not agree with the message of the cross of Christ;
2. false believers living in a worldly and immoral way (see 3:19); or
3. people who claimed to believe but rejected Paul's teaching that the good news centers on Christ's death on the cross (see 1 Corinthians 1:23; compare Romans 9:33; 1 Peter 2:8).

Philippians 3:19

- their god is their belly: This phrase may refer to their greed, sexcual desires, or self-interest (compare Romans 16:18).

- their glory is in their shame: This most likely refers to immoral behavior, not to pride in circumcision.
- Eternal destruction is God's ultimate judgment for those who reject Christ and live selfish, sinful lives (see 2 Thessalonians 1:8–9; compare Philippians 1:28; Matthew 7:13; Romans 9:22; 1 Corinthians 1:18; 2 Thessalonians 2:10; 1 Timothy 6:9; 2 Peter 2:3, 13; Jude 1:10; Revelation 11:18).
- their minds are set on earthly things: They cannot see beyond this life (compare John 12:25; 1 John 2:15–17).

Philippians 3:20

In contrast, believers know that their true home is in heaven with the Lord Jesus Christ (see Ephesians 2:19). So they focus their thoughts on heavenly things (see Colossians 3:1–2; compare 1 Corinthians 15:19; 1 Peter 2:11). They also focus their thoughts on Christ's return (see 1 Corinthians 1:7; Titus 2:13).

Philippians 3:21

- will transform our lowly bodies to be like His glorious body: When Jesus returns, he will transform believers' physical bodies. Instead of weak, aging bodies that die, they will have perfect, eternal bodies (see 1 Corinthians 15:42–54; compare Romans 8:23).
- enables Him to subject all things to Himself: This means that Jesus will have complete authority over all things. Everything in creation will be subject to his rule (see 1 Corinthians 15:24–27).

Philippians 4:1

- stand firm in the Lord: This means to remain faithful and committed to Jesus Christ (compare 1:27).
- Their ongoing faithfulness to Christ brought Paul great joy and was the reward for his hard work (see 1 Thessalonians 2:19–20).

Philippians 4:2

agree with each other in the Lord: The Lord's people should live in peace with one another (see 2:2; 1 Corinthians 1:10; Ephesians 4:1–3, 31–32; Colossians 3:12–15). We do not know what the disagreement between Euodia and Syntyche was about.

Philippians 4:2–9

Before ending the letter, Paul discusses a small conflict in the church and writes a few words of encouragement.

Philippians 4:3

- my true yokefellow (or loyal Syzygus): The Greek word suzuge is either a personal name or a description. We do not know exactly who this person was.
- Nothing more is known about Clement.
- whose names are in the Book of Life: Those whose names are written in the Book of Life are true believers. God will give them eternal life (see Luke 10:20; Revelation 3:5; 13:8; 17:8; 20:12, 15; 21:27; compare Exodus 32:32; Psalm 69:28; Daniel 12:1).

Philippians 4:4

- In Paul's letters, joy and rejoicing are a response to hearing the good news about Jesus (see Ephesians 5:19–20). Joy does not depend on circumstances. Instead, believers can have joy even when life is difficult.
- Rejoice! This is a command Paul often gives to Christians (see Philippians 2:18; 3:1; Romans 12:12, 15; 1 Thessalonians 5:16).

Philippians 4:4–6

Rejoice ... by prayer and petition ... with thanksgiving: Compare with 1 Thessalonians 5:16–18. Both passages were written to churches facing persecution (see also Romans 12:12).

Philippians 4:5

Believers should treat others with kindness and thoughtfulness, when those people are treating them badly or causing them to suffer for their faith. Believers do not need to seek revenge or try to get back at people who hurt them. Instead, they can trust that God will handle justice in his own time and way. Believers can act this way because they believe Jesus will return soon (see James 5:8–9).

Philippians 4:6

Believers do not need to worry, because their Father in heaven loves them and takes care of their needs. He invites them to pray about everything (see Matthew 6:25–34; 7:9–11; Romans 12:12; Ephesians 6:18; 1 Thessalonians 5:17; 1 Peter 5:7).

Philippians 4:7

Those who trust God (see 4:6) will experience God's peace (see also Isaiah 26:3; John 14:27; Colossians 3:15).

Philippians 4:8

Paul urges the Philippians to focus on God's good gifts. Then, even when they suffer and are treated badly by

others, they can live in a way that honors God and have peace in their hearts and mind (4:7, 9).

Philippians 4:9

Whatever you have learned or received or heard from me: This refers to everything Paul had taught them by word and example about the kind of life God wants us to live (see 3:17; 1 Corinthians 4:6, 16–17; 2 Thessalonians 3:7–9).

Philippians 4:10

It is not clear why they were not able to help him earlier.

Philippians 4:10–20

At the end of the letter, Paul thanks the Philippians for the gift they sent him through Epaphroditus.

Philippians 4:11–12

As a servant of Christ, Paul has learned to be content with every situation, whether he had plenty or little. His life was filled with the joy that comes from doing the will of God whatever the cost.

Philippians 4:13

through Christ: With Christ's help, Paul had the strength to do everything. In all situations, Paul relied on the strength of Christ, who lived in him and worked through him. This was especially true during times of suffering (see 2 Corinthians 1:8–10; 4:7–12; 12:8–10; Galatians 2:20; Colossians 1:27).

Philippians 4:14

The Philippians showed kindness and generosity, which was especially meaningful because Paul was suffering in prison.

Philippians 4:15

- no church but you partnered with me in the matter of giving: Paul chose not to accept money from the Corinthians, because he was concerned it might harm how they understood the good news about Jesus (1 Corinthians 9:11–18; 2 Corinthians 11:7–12). But he had no such concern with the Philippians.
- in the early days of the gospel: This refers to when Paul first preached the good news in Philippi (See Acts 16:11–40).

Philippians 4:16

After Paul left Philippi (see 4:15), he traveled to Thessalonica (see Acts 17:1–8; compare 1 Thessalonians 2:1–14).

Philippians 4:17

- Not that I am seeking a gift: Paul preferred to support himself financially (see Acts 18:3; 1 Corinthians 4:12; 9:3–18; 2 Corinthians 11:7–11; 12:14–15).
- Paul was not seeking a gift for himself. Instead, he wanted their generosity to produce spiritual fruit, a reward from God credited to their account

Philippians 4:18

- Epaphroditus had carried the gifts from Philippi (see also 2:25–30).
- They are a fragrant offering: In the Old Testament, acceptable offerings were a pleasing fragrance to God (see Leviticus 1:9, 13, 17; 2:2, 9; 3:5, 16; compare Romans 12:1; Ephesians 5:2).

Philippians 4:20

After thinking about God's wonderful blessings, Paul ends the letter with words of praise to God.

Philippians 4:22

Some people in Caesar's household were believers working for the Roman government. Paul might have share the good news about Jesus with them while he was in prison. They might have been especially close to Paul and worried about him in prison (see 1:13).

Philippians 4:23

- At the end of his letters, Paul often asks that the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ be with the people he is writing to (see also 1:2). Believers need Christ's grace for both salvation and daily life.
- Here, your spirit likely refers to the deepest part of the believers' inner being. The spirit is the part of the person that relates most directly to God. Paul is praying that Christ's grace would strengthen and sustain them at the core of who they are.